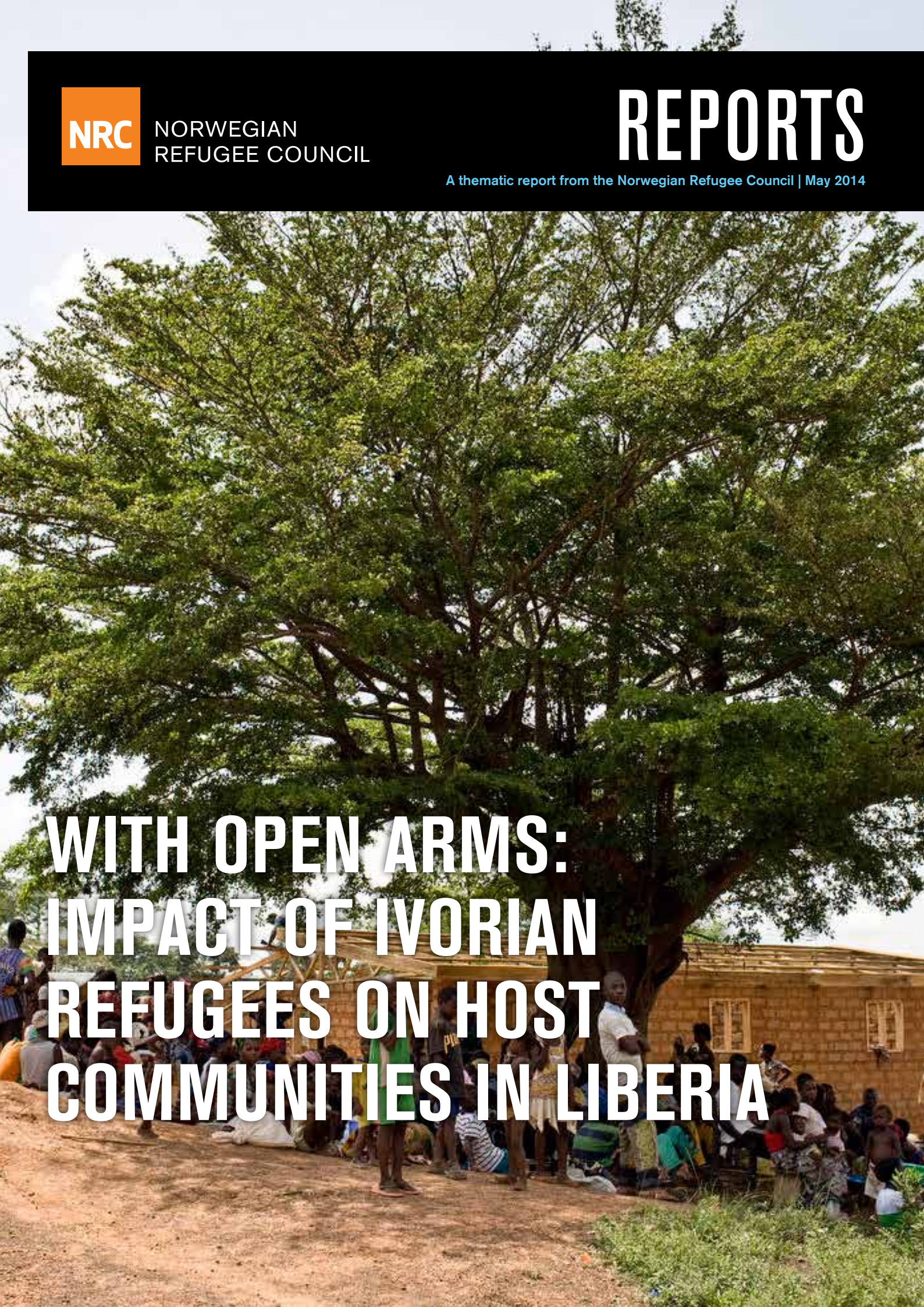




NORWEGIAN
REFUGEE COUNCIL

REPORTS

A thematic report from the Norwegian Refugee Council | May 2014



WITH OPEN ARMS: IMPACT OF IVORIAN REFUGEES ON HOST COMMUNITIES IN LIBERIA

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THE NORWEGIAN REFUGEE COUNCIL

The Norwegian Refugee Council (NRC) is an independent, humanitarian non-governmental organization that provides assistance, protection and durable solutions to refugees, internally displaced persons and returnees worldwide. To learn more about the NRC and its programmes, please visit our website: www.nrc.no

NRC IN LIBERIA

The 1989–2003 civil conflict in Liberia killed 200,000 people, displaced one million and devastated the country's infrastructure and economy. More than 100,000 former combatants have been demobilised and virtually all internally displaced persons and refugees have returned home or resettled. Despite this progress, Liberia's transition is fragile and serious humanitarian issues persist, including the meeting the needs of tens of thousands of people displaced into Liberia by the 2010 post-election crisis in Côte d'Ivoire. NRC has been working in Liberia since 2003 providing protection, humanitarian assistance and durable solutions to individuals and communities affected by displacement.

NRC IN CÔTE D'IVOIRE

The 2010 post-election crisis in Côte d'Ivoire displaced more than 950,000 people, with 700,000 displaced internally and more than 250,000 seeking refuge in neighboring countries. More than 81,000 people remain internally displaced and 83,000 refugees remain displaced in the region. Their return has been impeded in recent months due to increasing violence. NRC has been active in Côte d'Ivoire since 2006, providing protection, humanitarian assistance and durable solutions to individuals and communities affected by displacement. Our work since the 2010 post-election crisis has focused on ICLA, Food Security and Livelihoods, Education, Shelter and WASH programmes in the western part of the country.

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FOREWORD

This report is part of an effort to explore pilot initiatives that test the theory that assistance provided in countries where host governments strongly restrict the freedom of movement of refugees and IDPs (i.e. in camps) is costly, ineffective, offering very limited opportunities for self-reliance. As a result, humanitarian actors must push for “options beyond camp life”. NRC wishes to explore alternative models and approaches for assistance.

The development and testing of new approaches combined with research can provide evidence for implementing a holistic, refugee and (host) community-based model of assistance. Beyond NRC’s own operations, this research will inform NRC and the NMFA’s efforts to design, develop and support for new approaches to assisting displaced people in camp settings, and possibly strengthen the case towards host governments to allow more freedom of movement for displaced persons residing in camps.

Since 2006, NRC’s Information, Counseling and Legal Assistance (ICLA) project has assisted individuals and communities in Liberia to resolve land disputes resulting from the 1989–2003 civil conflict. The NRC undertakes similar land tenure and land conflict work in Côte d’Ivoire. The goal of NRC’s services is to support local communities, stakeholders and institutions to prevent, manage and resolve the challenges posed by displacement. The intention of this report is to provide original research and analysis that supports these efforts in Liberia and other post-conflict settings. To learn more, please visit the NRC Liberia at www.nrc.no

CONTENTS

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

FOREWORD

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

SECTION ONE: RESEARCH ON HUMANITARIAN
RESPONSE AND LOCAL INTEGRATION IN THE
FRAMEWORK OF DURABLE SOLUTIONS

Ivoirian Refugees In Liberia	8
Contingency Planning In Liberia	9
Research Design And Methodology	11
Host Community Profile	13
Refugee Profile	17

SECTION TWO: THE IMPACT OF HOSTING REFUGEES ON
PRE-DESIGNATED HOST COMMUNITIES IN LIBERIA

Economic Outcomes	18
Access To Services	19
Health	19
Education	20
Social Cohesion And Violence	21
Social Cohesion	24
Violence And Conflict	24

SECTION THREE: REFUGEE PREFERENCES AND
OUTCOMES

Displacement Location	26
Gender Analysis Of The Refugee Experience	27
Return	28

SECTION FOUR: WITH OPEN ARMS – IMPLICATIONS
FOR VULNERABILITY

Host Community Choices	31
------------------------	----

CONCLUSION

TECHNICAL ANNEX

Impact Or Effect Size	35
Statistical Significance And Confidence Intervals	35

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Host countries, international actors and first-responders make decisions about crisis management and humanitarian aid delivery that influence social cohesion, economic resilience, early recovery, and access to services for individuals and communities. Using the example of a 2010-2011 refugee policy implemented by the Government of Liberia (GoL) to assist refugees from neighboring Côte d'Ivoire, this study examines communities specifically selected to host refugees outside of camps across a range of outcomes to determine whether non-camp policies are feasible. This study finds that non-camp refugee policies in Liberia had no measurable negative impact on pre-selected host communities.

Following the 2010 presidential elections in Côte d'Ivoire and the violence that erupted in the West of the country during the ouster of former Ivoirian President Laurent Gbagbo, the GoL in collaboration with the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR) and other humanitarian actors implemented a contingency plan whereby refugees from Côte d'Ivoire were directed to settle in 15 villages pre-selected as host communities, as well as an additional community selected by the refugees (leading to 16 communities in total). This study is based on extensive qualitative and quantitative data collection in pre-designated host communities, as well as comparison communities not selected to specifically host refugees. The study also addresses a second set of questions related to a successful refugee hosting outside of camps with implications for programs that focus on Development through Local Integration (DLI) in the framework of durable solutions: When large numbers of refugees from diverse backgrounds exceed the capacities of communities, who are hosted, and who are overlooked? What is the influence of refugee identity, vulnerability, and remunerative capacity on whether refugees, IDPs and other persons of concern receive support from local communities, villages, and neighborhoods? These questions have important implications for who is most vulnerable during displacement crises.

The study finds:

- 1) The 16 Villages policy of local integration was not harmful to refugees or host communities.
- 2) Overall, refugees in 16 Villages communities had greater welfare than those who stayed in comparison communities.
- 3) There is no difference in measures of economic well-being or access to services for community members in the 16 Villages compared with community members in comparison communities.
- 4) Community members in 16 Village communities reported lower perceptions of trust and transparency within the host community, but they did not report increased conflict.
- 5) The 16 Village policy led to high levels of integration between refugees and host community members.
- 6) Social and cultural ties matter: the most economically weak refugees are not the most likely to be overlooked. Instead members of minority ethnic and religious groups are the most vulnerable during local integration.

The study analyzes the impact of the refugee crisis on individuals and communities by leveraging the choices made by refugees and stakeholders that led to different experiences during the crisis. The goal is to inform future policy choices during humanitarian emergencies and to assess the feasibility of policies that promote DLI. It is part of a larger effort to explore pilot initiatives that provide assistance to refugees and promote dignity, human rights and self-reliance. The study suggests that it is possible for humanitarian actors to push for “options beyond camp life” for all communities affected by displacement.

This report proceeds as follows. The first section provides background on local integration policies, the 2010-2011 Ivorian refugee crisis and the initial planning that went into the humanitarian contingency plan for displaced individuals from Côte d'Ivoire in Liberia. This section also gives information on study design, data collection methods and analysis. The third section compares outcomes in pre-designated host communities with similar communities that, while they hosted refugees, were not included in the initial policy. The fourth section uses quantitative data on refugee views and opinions to include the perspective of refugees of their experience during the crisis. In the fifth section, the study explores the question of vulnerability, and which refugees face the most substantial challenges in receiving support during local integration.

SECTION 1

RESEARCH ON HUMANITARIAN RESPONSE AND LOCAL INTEGRATION IN THE FRAMEWORK OF DURABLE SOLUTIONS

Camps provide people affected by violence and conflict a safe haven and a logistically feasible framework for providing life-saving humanitarian protection and assistance during humanitarian emergencies. Yet policy makers and advocates criticize the practice of settling displaced persons in camps¹. These critics argue that camps can lead to economic, social, security and environmental problems. In most contexts, refugee camps do not present a durable solution to an individual's displacement.

As a result, the policy makers and humanitarian actors seek alternatives to displacement camps, including self-settlement and pre-designated settlements for displaced persons within local communities. The Framework for Durable Solutions suggests that a "Development through Local Integration (DLI) approach would be an integrated one, aimed at creating an improved and conducive situation for refugees to become productive members of their host communities as well as improvements in the quality of life of host communities and refugees, realizing poverty reduction, promoting peace, security and stability in the region.

Although the DLI or non-camp refugee hosting policies provide a positive alternative to camps for both the displaced and for host communities, important questions remain unanswered about when and how to implement strong non-camp policies, especially from the perspective of host states and host communities. Does hosting refugees lead to negative outcomes for a hosting community? Are there potential positive impacts of displaced persons settling in pre-existing communities rather than creating new settlements or camps? What is host community member's perception and opinion of displaced persons?

Answering these and similar questions are necessary to develop coherent and effective humanitarian policy. This study explores one example of a non-camp policy. The larger goal is to create the tools for the national and local stakeholders in countries and regions that host displaced persons to choose the respectful and humane way to provide assistance to persons affected by conflict and violence.

IVOIRIAN REFUGEES IN LIBERIA

This study explores the case of the Ivoirian refugees in Liberia in 2010-2011. In October 2010, Ivoirians went to the polls in a climate of political instability to elect a new president. Previous conflict between the government and armed groups based in the north of the country between 2002 and 2010 led to cycles of violence, protracted disputes over land, displacement, and divided the country into a northern zone and southern zone². Following a presidential runoff between former Prime Minister Alassane Ouattara and then-President Laurent Gbagbo in November 2010, the international community came out in support of Ouattara as the democratically elected president; neither candidate conceded the election. Violence erupted between formal and informal armed groups concentrated in Abidjan and in Western Côte d'Ivoire. The situation forced many to seek refuge outside their communities of residence both within Côte d'Ivoire and across the border in neighboring country of Liberia.

¹ See, for example, see the August 1998 edition of the Forced Migration Review

² For further information, see NRC and IDMC, *Whose Land is This?* 2009 and NRC Land Conflict and Food Security in the Liberian-Ivoirian Border Region 2012.

In April 2011, the New Forces (FN), later renamed the Republican Forces of Côte d'Ivoire (FRCI), led a military assault from the north through Western Côte d'Ivoire on Abidjan and took control of the government. Gbagbo was taken into custody by the United Nations Mission in Côte d'Ivoire (ONUCI) and is currently in the International Criminal Court (ICC) in the Hague awaiting trial for war crimes.

Before it ended, the crisis displaced a quarter of a million people. According to the United Nations High Commission for Refugees (UNHCR), 150,000 sought asylum across the Liberian border in the regions of Nimba, Grand Gedeh, Maryland and River Gee. By the end of 2013, approximately 100,000 refugees had returned to Côte d'Ivoire while 50,000 remained in a series of refugee camps established along the Liberian-Ivoirian border.

CONTINGENCY PLANNING IN LIBERIA

Liberia is a small country of approximately 4 million people located on the coast of West Africa. The United Nations Human Development program ranks Liberia below the average for the World, Sub-Saharan Africa and other poor countries in terms of human development. Access to education, health and other government services is extremely poor; life expectancy at birth in 2011 is 54 years³. Liberia's lag in development is linked to cycles of violence and civil war that took place in Liberia between 1989 and 2003, displacing almost the entire population.

Even before the Liberian warring factions signed the 2003 Comprehensive Peace Agreement (CPA), instability in Côte d'Ivoire forced Ivoirians to seek shelter in Liberia. The remoteness of the Liberian Ivoirian border region and cross-border ethnic and linguistic ties created linkages across the border. During the final stages of the Liberian civil war, armed groups operated in the border zone and a brisk trade in weapons made the region unstable. Liberia hosted several thousand Ivoirian refugees, the majority in a camp outside the town of Saclepea, in Nimba county.

By 2005, elections heralded a new era of stability in Liberia. Yet politics remained volatile in Côte d'Ivoire. A group of refugees in the Saclepea camp declined to return, stating that they continued to fear persecution. Ongoing disputes over who had the right to Ivoirian citizenship and who controlled natural resources, including land used for lucrative coffee and cocoa farming led to protracted instability. As a result, UNHCR in cooperation with the Liberian government's Liberian Refugee Repatriation Resettlement Commission (LRRRC) developed contingency plans to host additional Ivoirian refugees should the need arise.

According to interviews, LRRRC decided to devise a policy that would allow a possible refugee influx to benefit Liberian communities through local development, and better security outcomes. As a result, the contingency planning process included host community settlement in the border region between Liberia and Côte d'Ivoire. Should a refugee emergency take place, LRRRC, in coordination with UNHCR and international aid agencies, would channel their support through these communities selected for this purpose, known as the "16 Villages" located in Nimba and Grand Gedeh counties⁴. Refugees would be encouraged to settle and aid agencies channel their support in these communities.

Liberians at LRRRC brought their own experience as refugees and IDPs to the contingency planning. The plan to pre-identify communities aimed to manage the complex logistical, social and security challenges created by a large movement of people during a violent conflict. In particular, the communities were located far enough away from the border to reduce what officials perceived as the potential that a conflict in Côte d'Ivoire could spill into Liberia. The planning also tried to address the real challenges that Liberians in the border regions would confront should they have to host refugees. Despite the generally accepted wisdom that refugees would pose a burden for host communities, officials tried to design a policy in line with the idea that at least the refugees would not harm the host communities where they settled and would, hopefully, bring some benefit to the communities asked to provide food, shelter, and health services to a large number of people.

Some limited evidence supports the idea that policies promoting development through local integration could work in the Liberian context. While some studies document the negative impacts of refugee flows (including the

³For further information on UNDP's Human Development Index, see <http://hdrstats.undp.org/en/countries/profiles/LBR.html>

⁴Throughout this report, the communities pre-selected as host-communities for Ivoirian refugees during the post-election crisis are referred to as the 16 Villages. Initially, the contingency planning included 15 villages; the addition of one village brought the total to 16. However, when speaking generally, we use the term "community" as opposed to village in order to take into account that these communities were not selected based on their designation as villages (with implications for the size of the community).

spread of disease, political instability and even civil war)⁵, other research has also shown that the arrival of refugees can bring unexpected benefits, specifically in West Africa. For example, in neighboring Guinea, areas that hosted refugees demonstrated better access to health services during one crisis.⁶ In Ghana, host communities adjacent to refugee camps experienced a range of benefits, including better access to infrastructure, such as commerce and the communication technology.⁷

Despite the positive evidence, there were also reasons for skepticism. The region of Liberia on the border with Côte d'Ivoire reports some of the highest levels of food insecurity in Liberia and lowest levels of government services.⁸ Prior to the post-election crisis, the history of violence during the Liberian civil war, the proliferation of non-state armed groups and the diffusion of small arms made the region prone to instability and conflict. Even if the arrival of refugees brought some benefits, the additional strain on natural and economic resources, on social structures and on local infrastructure presented a challenge to those communities that hosted refugees.

When Ivoirian refugees arrived in Liberia at the end of 2010 and 2011, they settled in the pre-selected host communities designated by LRRRC, as well as many other communities not previously selected, most of them near the border. Although the contingency planning prioritized the settling the refugees in pre-selected host communities, the size of the flows (many tens of thousands in the early months of 2011), meant that LRRRC felt additional settlement was needed. As the crisis grew, LRRRC in coordination with UNHCR constructed refugee camps to supplement the communities where refugees self settled along the border.⁹

RESEARCH DESIGN AND METHODOLOGY

The study design seeks to answer the following questions based key on comparative analysis of data collection in Liberia and in Côte d'Ivoire:

- What is the impact of pre-selection as a host community on communities and community members in Liberia?
- What was the experience of refugees during displacement and what is their current perspective on their communities of origin?
- What characteristics of refugees and host communities influence the choice to host refugees? When large numbers of refugees from diverse background exceed the capacities of subsistence communities, who is hosted, and who is overlooked?

The selection of the 16 Villages as host communities provides an excellent opportunity to study humanitarian policy and, specifically, the impact of designating host communities for local integration. The study analyzes the impact of the refugee crisis by comparing communities selected in the 16 Villages policy and 16 similar communities that were not. This comparison looks for meaningful differences between these two groups of communities across a range of outcomes to see whether they are a result of the 16 Villages policy.¹⁰

Conducting a survey in communities affected by the refugee crisis also presented an opportunity to explore the perspective of refugees on local integration. This information gives a profile of the kinds of refugees who benefited from the 16 Villages policy. Including refugee voices also permits an assessment of different asylum options (refugee camps, spontaneously chosen communities, and pre-designated communities).

Data was collected using two survey instruments that were specifically developed, field tested and verified in the field. In each community, enumerators asked 20 community members and four leaders if they were willing to participate in the data collection exercise (using pre-approved and standardized informed consent). There were no reports of unwillingness to participate in the survey. In each community, the team selected 20 community members using an

⁵For example see Sarah K. Lischer, "Dangerous Sanctuaries: Refugees, Civil War and Dilemma of Humanitarian Aid, Cornell University Press, 2006.

⁶See Van Dam et al, "Effects of a refugee-assistance programme on host population in Guinea as measured by obstetric interventions", *The Lancet*, 1999.

⁷See Kwame Gayu, "The socio-cultural and economic impact of refugees on the host indigenous communities in West Africa: a case study of Liberian refugees at Buduburam community in Ghana", 2008.

⁸NRC, *Food Security in the Liberia-Ivoirian Border region*, 2012.

⁹See Appendix A: Ivoirian Refugees in Liberia: 24/04/2011.

¹⁰Comparison communities were selected using Mahalanobis Matching, a statistical procedure in which each of the 16 Villages is "matched" to the most similar comparison community based on census data, including population, infrastructure, and geographic location.

interval sampling strategy to ensure all households (HH) had an equal probability of inclusion in the survey¹¹. In total, we surveyed 650 community members. 140 leaders, including the town chief, a female leader, a minority leader and a youth leader also participated. In the event that a community member randomly selected for participation was not available, the next available household was selected. In the event that a leader was not available, another leader with a similar post participated.

Using a similar survey instrument translated into French¹², the study collected data from refugees, both in refugee camps and across the border in Côte d'Ivoire (in return communities). In each refugee camp, approximately 50 refugees were interviewed; in each return community, 20-30 community members were interviewed, 41% of whom had been refugees. For all refugees in both samples, information was collected about their experience as a refugee, including where they settled (and if they changed where they settled, why) and their access to services and information about return. This data provides an additional perspective on the 16 Villages policy from the perspective of the refugees.

Finally, this study leverages an innovative survey simulation to uncover whether different types of refugee households are preferred by host community households. In the simulation, host community respondents consider a pair of refugee families with varying characteristics. They are then asked to choose which family they would host given limited resources, much as they had to do during the Ivorian refugee crisis. The simulation identifies a set of risk factors and protective factors that can influence the relationship between refugees and their host community.

HOST COMMUNITY PROFILE

This study relies on the fact that the communities selected as the comparison communities are as similar as possible to the communities selected for the 16 Villages policy (for example, in terms of the demographic profile of the community and the level of infrastructure) except that they were not pre-designated as communities to host refugees. When the communities are similar, the differences between the two groups of communities may be reasonably attributed to the 16 Villages Policy.

Table 1 provides basic demographic information about community members. 64% of household heads interviewed were male and 36% were female. Table 2 provides basic information about the communities for both the 16 Villages and the comparison communities from leaders. Columns 2 and 3 show the averages for the 16 Villages and the comparison communities, respectively, for a range of measures. Column 4 shows the size of the difference in the averages between these two groups and column five shows whether this difference is statistically significant, or meaningful. The differences are meaningful if the P-value is below .10.¹³ For example, the table shows 53% of the community members interviewed in the 16 Villages stated that they were literate, compared with 56% of the interviewees in the comparison communities. This difference is small (3%) and, given the number of people interviewed, not statistically significant. This suggests that there is not a meaningful difference in literacy levels between community members in the 16 Villages and in comparison villages.

Table 1 suggests that household heads in the 16 Villages and in comparison communities are very similar. These differences are so small, they are not expected to affect the impact of the 16 Village policy. In both groups, households have an average of 8 persons, household heads tend to practice traditional marriage (80%), they continue to live in their town of origin (79%), and they have limited levels of educational attainment.

¹¹Specifically, the enumeration team selected every 5th household along the major and minor paths in the village, until a sample of 20 households was reached.

¹²The data collected in Côte d'Ivoire was part of a baseline study conducted in the context of a programme evaluation of cross-border land dispute resolution and food security program in the Liberia-Côte d'Ivoire border region. The data collection strategies for this study and for that programme evaluation were designed to complement each other.

¹³A P-value is the result of a statistical test that gives an estimate of whether the difference between the average for the measure of a variable in the 16 Villages and the measure in the comparison communities is large enough, that, given the number of people interviewed (the number of observations), the difference between the groups is not an artifact of the people chosen for inclusion in the study. In other words, for P-values of less than .10, 9 times out of 10, if different people were randomly selected to take the survey in the community the difference between the communities is large enough that it would not disappear.

TABLE 1: PROFILE OF HOST COMMUNITY MEMBERS

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Number of Observations	16 Villages	Comparison Villages	Difference in Means	P Value
Are you the household head?	650	88%	89%	-0.01	0.62
Unmarried	649	11%	11%	0.00	0.95
Statutory marriage	649	4%	1%	0.03	0.02
Traditional Marriage	649	78%	83%	-0.05	0.13
Widowed	649	7%	5%	0.02	0.04
Living in town of origin	649	79%	79%	0.01	0.90
# of people in HH	650	8.06	8.13	-0.07	0.78
# of vulnerable people in HH	650	0.52	0.53	-0.01	0.92
Literate	647	53%	56%	-0.02	0.60
Male	650	64%	66%	-0.02	0.64
Female	650	36%	34%	0.02	0.64
18-25 years of age	651	25%	21%	0.04	0.20
25-35 years of age	651	28%	29%	-0.01	0.87
35-45 years of age	651	22%	23%	-0.01	0.77
45-55 years of age	651	13%	17%	-0.04	0.12
55+ years of age	651	12%	10%	0.02	0.54
No schooling	650	19%	16%	0.03	0.35
Elementary school	650	25%	25%	0.00	0.90
Junior high school	650	21%	27%	-0.06	0.06
Some high school	650	16%	17%	-0.01	0.93
Completed High school	650	12%	11%	0.01	0.64
Post secondary school	650	6%	4%	0.02	0.21

Table 2 presents data on the communities themselves and the refugees they hosted. The 16 Villages policy did impact on the number of household heads who reported hosting refugees with 70% of household heads in the 16 Villages stated that they hosted Ivorian refugees during the post-election crisis, compared with only 40% of households in comparison communities. The policy also succeeded in directing the humanitarian community to focus its support in the 16 Villages. More community members report NGOs provided assistance to their own households, either in providing shelter, rations and medical care in the 16 Villages compared with the comparison communities.

Slightly contrary to the other findings, 33% of household heads in the 16 Villages stated they received no refugee assistance (compared with only 23% in comparison communities). There could be several reasons why households in pre-selected host communities report receiving less support even though by others measures aid agencies provided more assistance in their communities. Perhaps, given the much higher number of households reporting that they hosted Ivorians in the 16 Villages, the support from NGOs was inadequate. Another possibility is that household heads in comparison communities had lower expectations of support and therefore were less likely to report receiving nothing than household heads in the 16 Villages.

The study also finds that less host community members in 16 Village communities reported refugees going back and forth to Côte d'Ivoire while they lived in the community compared with comparison communities. When refugees self-settle, they maybe more inclined to continue crossing back to the communities of origin compared to when they are settled in communities further from the border chosen by the host country government.

TABLE 2: PROFILE OF HOST COMMUNITIES

	(1) Number of	(2) 16 Villages	(3) Comparison Villages	(4) Difference in Means	(5) P Value
HH hosted refugees	568	70%	49%	22%	0.02
# of families hosted in community (leader estimate)	30	279.00	265.00	14.00	0.94
Refugees went back and forth to CI	30	19%	36%	17%	0.32
Refugees went back and forth to the camps	30	88%	57%	30%	0.07
Size of refugee HH	30	11.56	10.21	1.35	0.42
% of refugee HH headed by women	30	46%	45%	2%	0.78
% of refugee HH headed by children	30	48%	50%	2%	0.78
% of refugee HH directly affected by violence	30	6%	0%	6%	0.07
# of refugee HHs hosted	342	1.5	1.62	0.12	0.89
No NGO Assistance	653	33%	23%	10%	0.09
Shelter Assistance	653	17%	2%	15%	0.00
Rations	653	21%	16%	5%	0.47
Medical	653	7%	3%	3%	0.20

Overall, the data suggest that the members of the 16 Village communities and the comparison communities are similar on basic demographic characteristics, such as education, age, vulnerability and gender. The average size of the refugee household is 10 persons. Women headed almost 50% of the refugee households hosted and a similar number had directly experienced violence as a result of the post-election crisis in Côte d'Ivoire. These types of vulnerable households settled equally in 16 Village communities and comparison communities, while 16 Village communities hosted more households headed by children under 18 years of age. As expected, the 16 Villages policy did lead more households to host refugees and agencies to provide more support in designated communities.

REFUGEE PROFILE

The study also collected data on the refugee population. Table 3 shows demographic characteristics of refugees.

TABLE 3: PROFILE OF REFUGEES

	(1) Number of Observations	(2) Mean
Are you the household head?	176	96%
Unmarried	176	11%
Statutory marriage	176	4%
Traditional Marriage	176	78%
Widowed	176	7%
# of people in HH	176	4.40
# of people under 18 in HH	173	2.10
Literate	173	50%
Male	176	52%
Female	176	48%
18-25 years of age	176	25%
25-35 years of age	176	28%
35-45 years of age	176	22%
45-55 years of age	176	13%
55+ years of age	176	12%
% children in school	176	69%

Demographic information for refugees and host community members are similar. Refugees do report a smaller household size than host community members report, around 4-5 family members. This is smaller than both the size of host households and the estimated size of refugee households (by host household heads).

SECTION 2

THE IMPACT OF HOSTING REFUGEES ON PRE-DESIGNATED HOST COMMUNITIES IN LIBERIA

To understand the impact of the 16 Villages policy, the study explores the differences between pre-designated communities and comparison communities across a range of outcomes. These include measures of socio-economic success (including income, assets and farming), perceptions of access to services (health and education), the prevalence of violence and the level of social cohesion. Overall, the study suggests that the 16 Villages policy of local integration was not harmful to refugees or host communities and in some cases it was moderately beneficial.

ECONOMIC OUTCOMES

One reason why hosting countries are sometimes reluctant to promote local integration of refugees is the potential economic consequences of introducing presumably needy refugee populations to host communities. An increase in population could lead to a negative impact on economic activity and a depletion of development resources, especially in areas that are already vulnerable. To understand whether this was an unintended consequence of the 16 Villages policy, the study collects several measures of economic outcomes in both comparison communities and in the 16 Villages.

THERE IS NO DIFFERENCE IN THE MEASURES OF ECONOMIC WELL-BEING OF COMMUNITY MEMBERS IN THE 16 VILLAGES COMPARED WITH COMMUNITY MEMBERS IN COMPARISON COMMUNITIES.

TABLE 4: ECONOMIC OUTCOMES

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Number of Observations	16 Villages	Comparison Villages	Difference in Means	P Value
# of active farms	653	0.68	0.75	0.08	0.03
Total farm size	357	3.98	3.76	22%	0.79
Wealth index	653	3.24	3.15	9%	0.74
HH has a business	645	30%	32%	2%	0.54
Income last 7 days (USD)	605	0.42	0.39	0.03	0.37
Average 7 day income (USD)	583	0.42	0.40	0.02	0.78
Farmers group	32	100%	100%	0%	.

Table 4 shows economic outcomes (Graph 3 in the Annex represents this information visually). There is no difference in measures of economic well-being for community members in the 16 Villages compared with community members in comparison communities. Comparison community members are not wealthier, either in terms of weekly income (income in an average week or last week's income) or a household wealth index comprised of common assets (including livestock, small electronics and other assets). Hosting more refugees does not have a negative impact on economic development. The study does show that the reported number of active farms per household in 16 Villages communities is slightly lower than in comparison communities. While the difference is small in size, it is statistically significant. There are several possible explanations for this difference. First, the higher numbers of refugees hosted could have led to smaller farm sizes for host community households. Second, the increase in humanitarian aid as a result of the 16 Villages policy could have reduced farming and replaced it with other types of economic activities.

ACCESS TO SERVICES

Policies that support local integration intend to provide services both to refugees and host communities. Refugee influxes should not reduce access to services for the host population. In areas of resource scarcity, and where services are only directed toward camps, host communities may be concerned about a reduction in services as a result of refugees. To assess whether the 16 Village policy influenced access to services, the study measured services and outcomes for health and education.

HEALTH

The study does not find negative health outcomes for host community members. Host community members report increased refugee access to health services and food in the pre-designated host communities compared to other communities (more host community members report that refugees have the same or more access to health services compared with host community members in the 16 Villages). The policy did not lead to a decrease in meals for host community adults or children, or an increase in reported levels of children's hunger (see Table 5). Given that the high number of refugees in pre-designated host communities might have strained already existing resources, it could have been feasible that communities included in the policy had better health infrastructure (such as more public latrines and more wells) as a result of increased aid. The findings are suggestive: community leaders report more wells in pre-designated communities, and the result is statistically meaningful.

TABLE 5: HEALTH OUTCOMES

	(1) Number of Observations	(2) 16 Villages	(3) Comparison Villages	(4) Difference in Means	(5) P Value
Meals per day (ADULTS)	645	1.74	1.77	0.03	0.41
Meals per day (CHILDREN)	645	1.86	1.89	0.03	0.5
# of times in past 2 weeks a child went hungry	645	0.49	0.48	0.01	0.9
Refugees had same or more access to health	653	72%	52%	20%	0
Refugees had same or more access to food	653	56%	28%	27%	0
Community has birth attendant	32	88%	88%	0	1
Refugees had same or more access to food (leaders)	33	56%	6%	50%	0
Refugees had same or more access to health (leaders)	33	94%	65%	29%	0.07
# of wells	32	15.06	6.25	8.81	0.12
# of public latrines	32	18.31	18.44	0.13	0.99
Wash group	32	94%	100%	0.06	0.33

EDUCATION

The study finds similar results of the 16 Villages policy for education. Significantly more leaders and community members in the pre-designated host communities report that refugees have the same or more education than in comparison communities. 56% of host community leaders reported that refugees attended school in the 16 Village communities compared with only 18% in the comparison group. Graph 4 in the annex represents this information visually.

HOST COMMUNITY MEMBERS IN 16 VILLAGE COMMUNITIES REPORT THE SAME OR HIGHER ACCESS TO HEALTH AND EDUCATION SERVICES FOR REFUGEES.

Community leaders did report more educational facilities in pre-designated host communities, although the differences are not statistically meaningful. There are several possible explanations. Communities originally selected for inclusion in the 16 Villages policy may have had fewer facilities on average, and humanitarian aid during the crisis supported the infrastructure in these communities, bringing it in line with the infrastructure in other communities. Alternatively, the support directed towards the 16 Village communities did not focus on infrastructure, but instead provided resources for education in other ways. Finally, it is possible that while education aid should have been directed solely toward host communities, it also ended up helping in other communities as well.

TABLE 6: EDUCATION OUTCOMES

	(1) Number of Observations	(2) 16 Villages	(3) Comparison Villages	(4) Difference in Means	(5) P Value
Refugees had same/more access to edu as hosts	653	41%	25%	15%	0
Refugees had same/more access to edu as hosts (leaders)	33	44%	18%	26%	0.14
Primary school in community	32	100%	100%	0%	.
Junior High school in community	32	75%	56%	19%	0.28
Secondary school in community	32	19%	6%	13%	0.3
Refugees attend school in community	33	56%	18%	39%	0.03

SOCIAL COHESION AND VIOLENCE

Skeptics of policies of community hosting argue that refugees threaten social cohesion in the communities where they settle. They point to numerous historical examples where the presence of refugees is linked to the onset of problems, conflict and eventually violence in their host country. The presence of refugees can lead to conflicts between host community members as scarce resources grow scarcer, or create issues between refugees and hosts who may speak different languages, come from different backgrounds and in some cases have conflicting interests.

To explore the impact of the 16 Villages policy on both relations within the host community and relations between hosts and refugees, the study collected data on dynamics in the community as a whole, as well as the attitudes of host community members towards refugees. The study finds that the impact of the 16 Village policy on social cohesion is mixed. 16 Village communities report higher levels of integration of refugees. At the same time, some measures of social cohesion between host community members are lower in pre-designated communities. Overall, however, communities selected for inclusion in the 16 Villages policy did not experience higher levels of violence than comparison communities and a large majority of community members in the 16 Villages (82%) reported that refugees gave more than they took from the community.

TABLE 7: SOCIAL COHESION

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	Number of Observations	16 Villages	Comparison Villages	Difference in Means	P Value
Frequency of community meetings	649	3	2.76	0.24	0.01
Contribute to community, past 4 weeks	649	1.63	2.07	0.44	0.05
Support neighbors, past 4 weeks	649	0.65	0.67	0.02	0.6
# ethnic groups in social activities	649	1.27	1.29	0.02	0.91
Easy to get help in community	635	70%	78%	9%	0.02
Disrespect of personal rights in community	639	38%	35%	3%	0.39
Community is safe from theft	643	54%	58%	4%	0.49
Community is safe at night	640	61%	66%	5%	0.23
Trust between community members	647	81%	79%	3%	0.59
Trust of outsiders	634	34%	33%	1%	0.75
Equal rights for outsiders	639	79%	77%	1%	0.72
Transparency of community decision making process	636	82%	89%	8%	0
Voice in community decision making process	639	77%	85%	8%	0.01
Access to fair judgement	640	92%	95%	3%	0.05
Satisfaction with community leaders	640	86%	90%	4%	0.2
Corruption of traditional leaders	605	39%	34%	5%	0.22
Fairness of traditional leaders	638	85%	89%	4%	0.08
Refugees and host community share values	503	91%	83%	8%	0.06
Refugees gave more than they took from community	507	82%	26%	56%	0
Refugees brought benefits to the community	468	8%	5%	3%	0.16
Refugees married in community	653	38%	21%	17%	0
Refugees got disputes resolved in community	653	39%	29%	11%	0.04
Refugees made farm in community	653	36%	23%	13%	0.04
Refugees exchanged sex for refuge	653	17%	7%	9%	0.01
Elder's group in community	32	100%	100%	0%	.
Women's group in community	32	100%	100%	0%	.
Youth group in community	32	100%	100%	0%	.
Children's group in community	32	69%	63%	6%	0.72

SOCIAL COHESION

Table 7 compares outcomes for the 16 Village communities and the comparison communities. Community members report attending slightly more community meetings in pre-designated host communities compared with community members in the comparison group. However, more community members in comparison communities report providing money to support community activities and report that it is easy to get help in their community compared with the 16 Villages communities. Although the difference is small, more community members in comparison communities report transparency in community decision-making processes and report that they themselves have a voice in community governance. This suggests that perhaps more transparency and inclusion were needed when leaders made decisions about how resources to support both host community members and refugees should be used.

A CRITICAL MEASURE OF LOCAL INTEGRATION IS PERSONAL RELATIONSHIPS: HOST COMMUNITIES REPORT REFUGEES MARRYING HOST COMMUNITY MEMBERS MORE FREQUENTLY IN 16 VILLAGE COMMUNITIES.

Conducting a survey in communities affected by the refugee crisis also presented an opportunity to explore the perspective of refugees on local integration. This information gives a profile of the kinds of refugees who benefited from the 16 Villages policy. Including refugee voices also permits an assessment of different asylum options (refugee camps, spontaneously chosen communities, and pre-designated communities).

The data suggest that the 16 Village policy did increase reported levels of refugee integration in pre-designated host communities. In 16 Village communities, more host community members report that refugees and host community members share values and that refugees gave more than they took in the community. A critical measure of integration is personal relationships; the study finds that host communities report refugees marrying host community members more frequently in 16 Village communities. However, a note of caution should be sounded: more host community members reported that refugees exchanged sex for refuge in the 16 Villages than in comparison communities.

VIOLENCE AND CONFLICT

A key reason why national governments and host communities are reluctant to host refugees is the threat of violence and conflict. Potential violence could take place between different groups of refugees (in particular when both sides of a civil war are represented within the refugee population), between the members of the host population (in the case where refugees place additional strains on scarce resources) and between host community members and refugees. In the Liberian-Ivoirian border region, conflict over land is common and in some cases escalates into violence. As a result, the study explores the incidence of land disputes in the two groups of communities, as well as other measures of violence and crime.

TABLE 8: VIOLENCE OUTCOMES

	(1) Number of Observations	(2) 16 Villages	(3) Comparison Villages	(4) Difference in Means	(5) P Value
Land dispute in the past 12 months	653	18%	19%	1%	0.71
Serious land disputes in the past 12 months	653	8%	9%	1%	0.53
Violence associated with a land dispute in the past 12 months	653	6%	6%	1%	0.67
Any serious crime	653	27%	28%	1%	0.79
Number of palava huts	32	1.06	0.44	63%	0
Peace group in community	32	69%	44%	25%	0.16

Table 8 shows that there is no difference in the incidence of land disputes (including serious and violent disputes) in pre-designated host communities and the comparison group over the past year. Similarly, host community members do not report a difference in the incidence of serious crime in the two groups of communities.

CRIME, CONFLICT AND VIOLENCE DID NOT OCCUR WITH HIGHER FREQUENCY IN THE 16 VILLAGES COMMUNITIES.

Community members in pre-designated communities reported more palava huts (structures built for communities to use for meetings and gathers in the dispute resolution process). Overall, while community members in comparison communities report slightly higher levels of social cohesion, the 16 Villages policy did succeed in integrating refugees into pre-designated host communities without increasing most measures of conflict.

SECTION 3

REFUGEE PREFERENCES AND OUTCOMES

Refugee experience during displacement is key to understanding local integration policy. Ivorian refugees in Liberia sought multiple solutions to their displacement and the study aimed to capture differences between experiences in these displacement locations. Overall, refugees report higher access to services and work in 16 village communities compared with comparison communities. In addition, a gender analysis of the data suggests that women experienced their displacement in Liberia differently than men on key issues. For example, a higher proportion of female refugees report exchanging sex for food and other services.

The study also explores the links between refugees and their communities of origin in Côte d'Ivoire. The data suggest that there is contact between refugees and their social networks across the border. Refugees continue to cite security concerns as reasons why they do not wish to return.

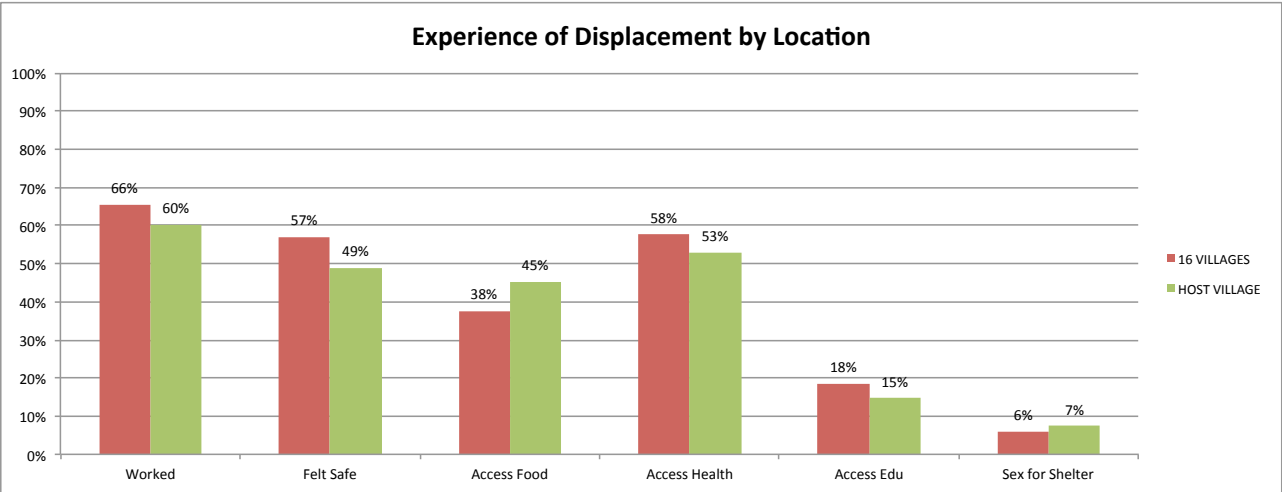
DISPLACEMENT LOCATION

The study collected information on where refugees sought refuge during their displacement. Table 9 shows the average response for refugees. On average, refugees stayed in between 3 and 4 locations. All refugees surveyed had spent time in one of the refugee camps.

TABLE 9: DISPLACEMENT LOCATION

	(1)	(2)
	Number of Observations	Mean
# of places stayed	183	3.83
Has stayed in refugee camp	183	100%
Has stayed in countryside	183	11%
Has stayed in another of the 16 Villages	183	7%
Has stayed in other host village	183	57%

Table 4 shows economic outcomes (Graph 3 in the Annex represents this information visually). There is no difference. Refugees did report different experiences depending on the location where they settled. Graph one shows refugee perceptions of their own access to services based on their displacement location (if they had ever spent time in a 16 village community or another host community).



More refugees who stayed in 16 village communities reported better access to services than refugees who had spent time in other host communities. Similarly, a higher proportion of refugees who spent time in 16 village communities reported that they worked. While a larger proportion of refugees reported access to food in comparison communities, refugees who spent time in those communities were also slightly more likely to report having exchanged sex for shelter compared with refugees who had spent time in 16 village communities.

GENDER ANALYSIS OF THE REFUGEE EXPERIENCE

Gender plays an important role in the refugee experience. A gender analysis of data collected on the refugee experience gives an important perspective on the specific perspective of women during their displacement.

TABLE 10: REFUGEE EXPERIENCES

	(1) Mean (Total pop)	(2) Female (40% of total pop)	(3) Difference between Male and Female	(4) P Value
Duration stayed (months)	13.55	13.82	0.47	0.71
Worked	59%	51%	14%	0
Felt Safe	61%	61%	1%	0.71
Had access to food	50%	54%	7%	0.06
Had access to health services	67%	67%	1%	0.83
Had access to education	26%	28%	2%	0.52
Exchanged sex for food or shelter	6%	9%	5%	0.04

Table 10 shows the mean for the entire refugee population and for women (approximately 40% of the total sample). Column 3 shows that difference between the mean for women and the mean for men. On average, refugees were displaced for just over 13 months at the time of the interviews for this study (no difference for men and women). A very high proportion of refugees (60% of men and 50% of women) reported working during their displacement, with more men reporting that they worked than women. Overall around 60% of refugees reported feeling safe in their current location of refuge, with no difference for male and female refugees. While a majority of refugees reported access to health services and food, only about a quarter of refugees reported access to education. Female refugees had the same or slightly better access to food and services, but they also more frequently report exchanging sex for food.

RETURN

In addition to information on the locations where refugees sought refuge during displacement and the different experiences of men and women, the study also collected data on refugees' perceptions about the conditions in their communities of origin in Côte d'Ivoire.

TABLE 11: REFUGEE RETURN

	(1) Number of Observations	(2) Mean
Gone back to Cote d'Ivoire in past 6 months	174	9%
Length since last talked to someone in CI (months)	174	2.65
Few people have returned to my village	183	40%
Most people have returned to my village	183	15%
Don't know how many people returned to my village	183	39%
House is still standing if I return home.	165	6%
Housespot land is available for me if I return home.	174	50%
FRI are harrasing or abusing certain groups of people in home area	129	81%
Police are harrasing or abusing certain groups of people in home area	127	55%
Dozos are harrasing or abusing certain groups of people in home area	131	87%
Economic opportunities exist on return	160	9%

Table 11 shows that few refugees interviewed (around 9%) returned to their communities of origin to "go and see" in the past six months. They were, however, receiving information about Côte d'Ivoire (on average, they spoke with someone in the previous three months). The general perception amongst refugees was that most people in their communities had not returned and that levels of harassment by various security forces and armed groups were high. About 50% of those interviewed thought that their land was still available if they returned and even fewer (around 6%) thought that their houses were still standing. Perhaps unsurprisingly, most refugees did not perceive economic opportunities in their communities of origin.

REFUGEES PERCEIVED HIGH LEVELS OF INSECURITY, INCLUDING REDUCED ACCESS TO LAND AND THE THREAT OF HARASSMENT BY ARMED GROUPS AND SECURITY FORCES IN THEIR COMMUNITIES OF ORIGIN.

SECTION 4

WITH OPEN ARMS – IMPLICATIONS FOR VULNERABILITY

If policies that promote durable solutions through local integration succeed, do they work equally for all refugees? Evolution in refugee policy has led to programs that focus on providing goods and services to the most vulnerable refugees, including women-headed households and refugees without access to food. In some refugee crises, communities host refugees of different backgrounds, including different religious practices, ethnic identities and language groups. This study finds that members of groups with big social and cultural differences between themselves and the host population find it more difficult to find shelter than refugees that share social and cultural ties with the host communities.

HOST COMMUNITY CHOICES

This study considers the question how vulnerability and social distance affects DLI policies by collecting information on the preferences of host community households. During our data collection, host community members are asked to imagine a new refugee crisis and about hosting a hypothetical refugee household with different characteristics. The preferences of host community members were compared for each different kind of refugee household.¹⁴

TABLE 12: REFUGEE RETURN

	(1) Number of Observations	(2) Mean
Gone back to Cote d'Ivoire in past 6 months	174	9%
Length since last talked to someone in CI (months)	174	2.65
Few people have returned to my village	183	40%
Most people have returned to my village	183	15%
I don't know how many people returned to my village	183	39%
My house is still standing if I return home.	165	6%
My houseplot land is available for me if I return home.	174	50%
The FRI are harrassing or abusing certain groups of people in your home area	129	81%
The police are harrassing or abusing certain groups of people in your home area	127	55%
The Dozos are harrassing or abusing certain groups of people in your home area	131	87%
Economic opportunities exist if I return	160	9%

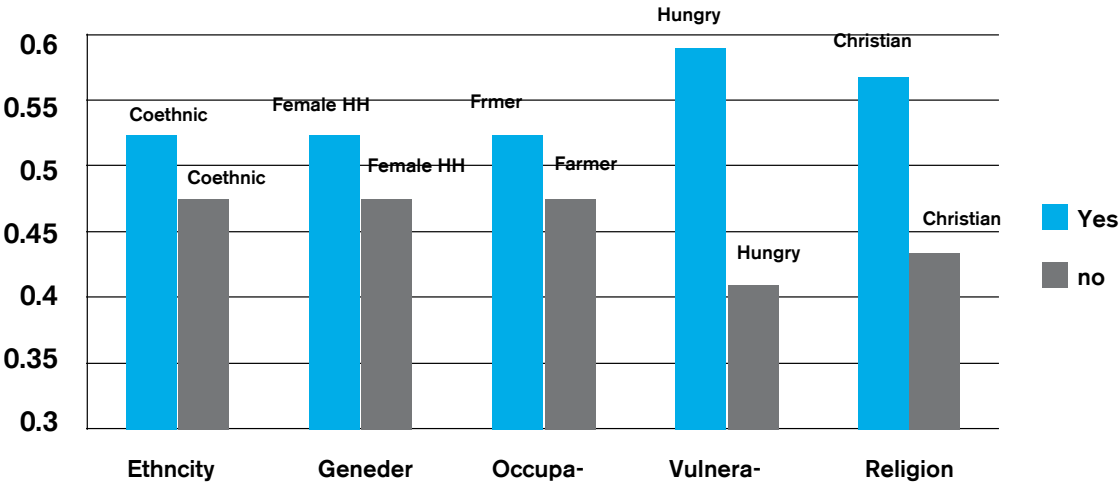
¹⁴This is known in social science as a "survey experiment" because an individual who participates in the survey randomly receives a choice between hosting one type of refugee household and another.

TABLE 13: REFUGEE ATTRIBUTES

Attribute	Level 1	Level 2
Gender of HH	Male	Female
Ethnicity	Coethnic	Not Coethnic
Religion	Christian	Muslim
Occupation	Farmer	Not Farmer
Food	Hungry	Not Hungry

Graph 2 shows the preferences that host communities have for different types of hypothetical refugee households. The categories of refugees include Muslim headed households, female headed households, households with limited resources (“hungry” households), households with some ability to make farms and assist their hosts, and refugees that share ethnic and linguistic links with the host communities. Each profile is composed of two attribute levels, as listed in Table 12, and each level is randomly assigned within each refugee profile.

WILLINGNESS TO HOST REFUGEES



The study finds that rather than refusing to take vulnerable refugees, host community households actually express a preference for hosting refugee with limited resources. Host community households also have a slight preference to host female headed households. The survey also suggests that host community households prefer not to host Muslim-headed households.

SOCIAL AND CULTURAL TIES MATTER: THE MOST ECONOMICALLY WEAK REFUGEES ARE NOT THE MOST LIKELY TO BE OVERLOOKED; INSTEAD MEMBERS OF MINORITY ETHNIC AND RELIGIOUS GROUPS ARE THE MOST VULNERABLE DURING LOCAL INTEGRATION.

Taken together, the study suggests that contrary to the hypothesis that the most economically vulnerable refugees might suffer under policies that promote local integration, vulnerable households are preferred by some host families. At the same time, host community members do not prefer households with a larger social and cultural distance from themselves (in this context is represented by Muslim-headed households). When creating and implementing policies of local integration, care must be taken to provide support for refugees families that do not share the same cultural ethnic, religious cultural background as the host communities.

CONCLUSION

The Framework for Durable Solutions for Refugees and Persons of Concern proposes several different solutions for persons affected by displacement. Development through Local Integration and non-camp refugee policies are two paths to provide assistance to refugees, host communities and others affected by displaced outside of camps. This study shows that despite fears that hosting refugees in communities might lead in the worst cases to increased conflict or at least to negative economic outcomes, this does not have to be the case.

This study finds that overall refugees accessed services and achieved high levels of social integration under a policy of non-camp hosting. Levels of conflict, including highly contentious land disputes, were not higher in communities designated to host refugees. Some measures of social cohesion, in particular the trust of host community members in their local governance structures, did decrease in communities selected to host refugees. However, these findings may be the result of the natural friction that results when a community grows to accept outsiders, regardless of whether they are refugees or not given the much higher numbers of refugees that pre-designated communities hosted. Especially when refugees and host communities share social and cultural ties, host community members are willing to host those in need of assistance.

In some contexts, host countries insist that refugees receive asylum and services in camps to reduce the negative externalities associated with hosting those fleeing violence and conflict. In other countries, refugee camps may be both logistically unrealistic and politically undesirable. The massive influx of Syrian refugees into neighboring countries throughout the Middle East provides one example of hundreds of thousands of refugees who receive assistance within host communities rather than refugee camps. The data in this study suggest that non-camp refugee hosting can present an opportunity to provide asylum with dignity for both refugees and host communities alike.

TECHNICAL ANNEX

We set out to write a report that is free of excessive technical jargon. While we believe that the lessons of the report can be understood without a background in statistics, there are a few concepts that are good to review.

IMPACT OR EFFECT SIZE

Simply put, impact or effect size refers to the size of the difference between groups when evaluating outcomes. In this report, “impact” refers to the average difference between people in the pre-designate host communities (“intervention” group) and people in comparable communities that were not pre-designated host communities (“comparison” group). The difference can be framed as an absolute value (e.g. an increase of \$X dollars in income for the average citizen) or as a percentage of the increase relative to the comparison group (e.g., the impact is equivalent to an increase of 50% over the mean in comparison communities).

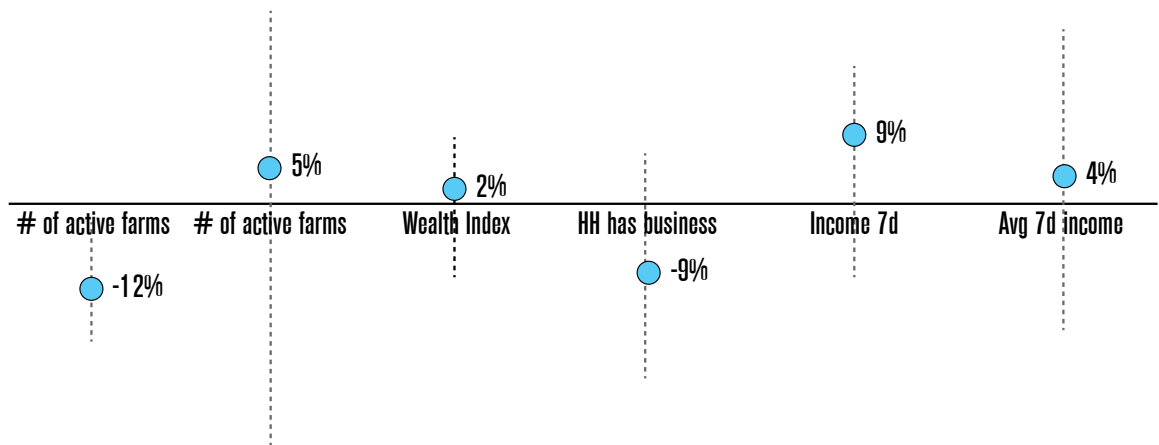
STATISTICAL SIGNIFICANCE AND CONFIDENCE INTERVALS

When we calculate average effect size, we compare the average in pre-designated host communities to the average in the comparison communities. Both groups contain a great deal of variation in the outcome variables, and this implies that any average effect is measured with error. This error decreases as we increase the number of people in the sample, but some uncertainty always remains.

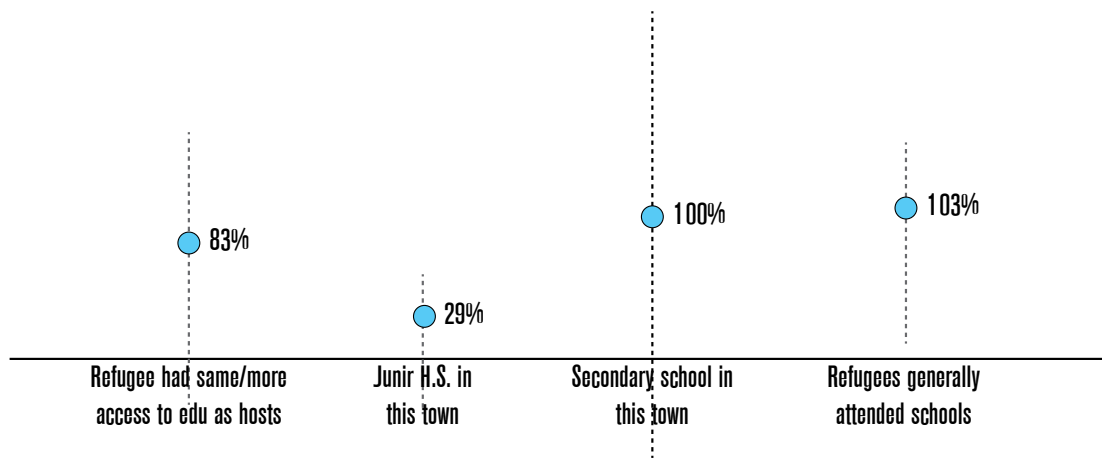
When we detect an average difference between the intervention and comparison group, we want to know whether or not we can say with confidence that the difference is not zero. In any study, the default hypothesis, also known as the “null” hypothesis, is always that there is no intervention effect. In statistics, a result is called statistically significant if it is unlikely to have occurred by chance under the null hypothesis. Conventionally, we regard a result as statistically significant if there is a less than 5% risk that it is not zero.

Of course, we are not merely satisfied to know that a result is not zero. We would like to know the possible range of error around our average treatment effect. How high or low could the true value be? One way to evaluate our results is to report confidence intervals. Confidence intervals tell us the range of values that our finding could take with 95% or 90% significance. Graphs 3-5, reproduced below, report the estimated effect size along with the range or “confidence interval” in which the “true” effect size falls with 90% confidence. For example, in Graph 3, we can see that the confidence interval for the estimated effect on the “Wealth Index” crosses zero. Therefore, we are not confident that the pre-designated host community intervention had an impact on individual’s wealth. Conversely, we can see that the number of active farms in pre-designated communities decreased by 12%, a result that is statistically significant.

Impact on Economic Outcomes



Impact on Educaiton Services



Impact on Conflict

